

9.69

SECONDS

USAIN BOLT'S RECORD IN THE 100M SPRINT



Usain Bolt became the fastest man on Earth when he sprinted his way to a new 100m world record at the Summer Olympics in Beijing.

THIS WAS THE YEAR OF "BLACK MONDAYS" in the world of **finance**. On Monday, January 21, the London Stock Exchange experienced a dramatic fall in overall value. On Monday, September 15, the US investment firm **Lehman Brothers** declared **bankruptcy**, and on the US stock market the Dow Jones Industrial Average lost 4.4 percent of its value. On Monday, September 29, there was a 7-percent drop in the Dow.



BARACK OBAMA (1961–)

Democrat Barack Hussein Obama made history when he was elected to the White House as the 44th President of the US. Born in Hawaii, he is the first African-American to hold the office, and gained admirers for his relaxed charm and stirring oratory. However, his first year met with fierce opposition as he attempted to change the American healthcare system, tackle climate change, and reach new agreements on nuclear disarmament.

The Australian prime minister **Kevin Rudd** (b. 1957) made an official **apology** for years of mistreatment inflicted on the country's **Aboriginal** people on February 13. He singled out the "Stolen Generations"—mixed-race children who were forcibly removed from their families under a government-sanctioned policy of white assimilation.

On January 7, New Jersey became the first Northern state in the US to apologize for its part in the slave trade. It prohibited the importation of slaves after 1786, but was the last Northern state to emancipate them.

Democrat **Barack Obama** won the US presidential election on November 4, becoming the first African-American president, and winning 52.5 percent of the popular vote. Obama's main rival was Republican **John McCain**.

Cuba's leader, **Fidel Castro**, **retired** after half a century on February 19. He had not appeared in public since undergoing stomach surgery. Castro's brother, **Raúl**, became president.

Pakistan's president **Pervez Musharraf** bowed to intense pressure and **resigned** on August 18 ahead of impeachment proceedings. He launched a passionate defense of his record.

India suffered a series of coordinated **terrorist attacks** on November 28 across the city of **Mumbai**—166 people were killed. India blamed the attacks on Pakistan-based militant groups, and the attacks derailed peace talks between the two nations.

Kosovo declared **independence** from Serbia on February 17, but the legitimacy of this was disputed. Kosovo's bid to be recognized as Europe's newest country was the latest episode in the dismemberment of the former **Yugoslavia**, 17 years after its dissolution began.

Radovan Karadzic, Europe's most wanted man, was **arrested** on July 21. The former Bosnian Serb leader had been on the run for 12 years, fleeing charges of genocide.

South Ossetia became the focus of a **war** between Russia and Georgia in August when it tried to **break away** from Georgia. Georgia launched a full military offensive to try to reconquer the region, which led to violent clashes with Russia. After Georgia's troops were ejected, Russia withdrew and recognized South Ossetia's independence.

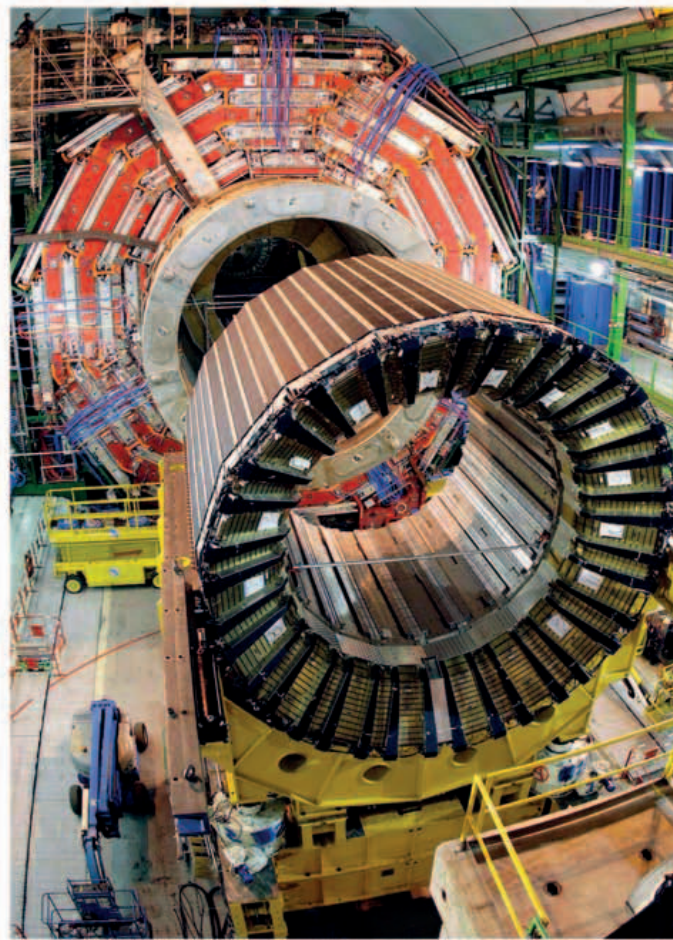
Irish voters plunged the **EU** into disarray on June 13 by **rejecting** the **Lisbon Treaty**, which was designed to bring more European integration. All European member states had to ratify the treaty for it to go into force in 2009. It had been approved by 18 countries, but Ireland was the only one to put the treaty to a public vote.

Usain Bolt sprinted into history with a world-record-breaking run on August 16 at the Summer

Olympics held in **Beijing**, China. Bolt, from Jamaica, ran the 100m final in a time of 9.69 seconds, breaking his own record of 9.72 seconds set earlier in 2008. The decision to pick Beijing as the host for the Summer Olympics of 2008 was controversial, as critics cited China's record of human rights violations. The event became a

source of enormous national pride for China.

Twenty years in the making, the world's largest "atom smasher," the **Large Hadron Collider**, built near Geneva, Switzerland, was started on September 10. It was designed to look at the "Big Bang" and other mysteries of the universe.



The Hadron collider at CERN
The most intricate machine ever built, it is hoped that the Large Hadron Collider will unravel the mystery of how the universe began.

